organizations emphasized the ICC's role in ensuring justice.[110] Countries like Senegal, Botswana, Sierra Leone, and Nigeria publicly defended the Court, providing a counternarrative to the populist critiques in the region.[111] Regional coalitions, including the African Group for Justice and Accountability, also mobilized to encourage countries like South Africa to reconsider withdrawal.[112] Connections with these international partners served to isolate skeptical leaders.

The ICC also sought to appease critics by broadening its focus beyond Africa, thereby addressing accusations of regional bias. In 2016, it opened investigations into crimes committed in Afghanistan and Georgia and later initiated inquiries into Venezuela's government and the Russian invasion of Ukraine.[113] These actions demonstrated the Court's willingness to pursue justice on a global scale, not just within African states. The ICC also facilitated open debates about its operations, providing forums for member states and the public to voice concerns and propose reforms.[114]

Despite these efforts, populist opposition to the ICC remains a persistent and evolving challenge. While the Court successfully retained most of its African membership, skepticism about its fairness and efficacy continues to resonate among populist leaders and their supporters (Helfer and Showalter 2017). This ongoing hostility underscores the broader tension between IOs and populist movements, which frequently invoke sovereignty concerns and anti-elitism to challenge global governance. The ICC's long-term success will depend on its ability to navigate these ideological divides while maintaining its commitment to justice.

8.13 Implications and Discussion

Our case studies illustrate a consistent pattern: No matter the nature of the state led by populists or the type of IO they challenge, IOs have responded in ways that align with the strategies we theorize—appeasing and sidelining leaders and their constituents. Across a wide range of examples, we see IOs and their members offering tangible concessions to populist leaders, such as fighter jets, trade incentives, and policy adjustments, while simultaneously reinforcing alliances with other states and organizations to mitigate risks if appeasement efforts fell short. Concurrently, IOs have worked to engage and mollify populist constituents, leveraging social media platforms like